A Second Life

Opportunity, Choice, and Luck Along the Roads Not Taken

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Abstract

Imagine living a second life: would we make the same choices, and what might have followed from opportunities we missed or never encountered? Through a long-tenured professional, a lifelong hometown resident, and a student who narrowly misses a medical-school qualification, this essay examines what a realized life can conceal about aspirations, attempted choices, constraints, and consequential events. It distinguishes historical reconstruction of what occurred from scenario analysis of what might have occurred, and considers how opportunity, choice, and luck shape both subsequent possibilities and retrospective judgments. Although alternative lives cannot be observed, revisiting the roads not taken can deepen our understanding of the life we actually lived.

Keywords: life trajectories; historical reconstruction; scenario analysis; counterfactual thinking; opportunity; choice; luck; regret

1. If We Could Live Again

Imagine that we could return to an earlier point in our lives and begin again. Would we make the same decisions, pursue the same opportunities, and follow the same paths? Or would we choose differently, hoping to experience a life that might otherwise remain unknown?

Consider a professional who has spent forty years working for the same company. The career has been satisfying in many respects. The professional has developed expertise, established lasting relationships, and enjoyed considerable stability. Yet, approaching retirement, the person might wonder what working for another company would have been like. Would a different environment have brought new challenges, different colleagues, or unexpected interests? Would the person have developed differently?

Now consider someone who has lived an entire life in the same hometown. The individual may have enjoyed close family relationships, a familiar community, and a strong sense of belonging. Yet the person might wonder what living in a distant city or another country would have been like. Would unfamiliar surroundings have offered richer experiences? Would meeting different people have changed the direction of life?

Neither individual needs to be dissatisfied. Both may have good reasons to value the lives they have lived. Nevertheless, each may recognize that other possibilities were left unexplored.

Such reflections invite us to imagine a second life. But they also raise questions about the first. How did our lives become what they are? Which opportunities did we pursue, which did we decline, and which never became available? How much depended on choices we made, and how much on circumstances and events we could neither anticipate nor control?

To explore the lives we might have lived, we can begin by unwinding the one that actually unfolded.

2. Unwinding the Life We Lived

Return to our long-tenured professional.

At age thirty-five, after ten years with one employer, the professional receives an attractive offer from another company. The new position promises broader responsibilities and exposure to a different organizational environment.

After considering the offer, the professional decides to remain.

Perhaps the current position provides financial security and satisfying work. Perhaps family responsibilities make changing employers less attractive. Or perhaps the alternative does not offer enough advantages to justify leaving.

Thirty years later, the professional wonders whether declining the offer was a missed opportunity.

To understand that decision, we need to return to the circumstances in which it was made. What did the professional know about the two employers? What opportunities and constraints existed? What did the person value at the time? These questions recover the decision as it appeared then, before the consequences of remaining became known.

We can then trace what happened afterward. Remaining may have enabled the professional to develop specialized expertise, establish long-term relationships, and assume new responsibilities. Those experiences could have changed later opportunities and made staying attractive again. A forty-year career may therefore have emerged through successive decisions to remain, rather than a single decision to spend an entire working life with one employer.

The hometown resident's life might have developed similarly. An initial preference to remain near family may have been followed by local employment, marriage, homeownership, and deeper community relationships. Over time, these developments may have increased the value of staying while making relocation more difficult.

The professional and hometown resident illustrate how earlier experience can change both the appeal of staying and the difficulty of leaving. Life-course research situates individual development within changing historical and social circumstances [1]. Our earlier essay How We Get Where We Are examines how earlier opportunities and outcomes become conditions governing later choices [2]. Here that relationship helps explain why a long period of continuity may contain a succession of changing decisions.

But consider a different version of the professional's history.

Suppose the individual did not decline an offer. Instead, the person applied for a position elsewhere, completed several interviews, and narrowly failed to receive an offer.

The eventual employment history would still show forty years with one company, but it would have a different explanation. In one version, the professional chose to remain despite having another offer. In the other, the professional tried to leave but did not obtain the intended opportunity. The same visible career can therefore conceal different aspirations, decisions, and experiences.

The hometown resident may likewise have considered relocation, applied for employment elsewhere, or pursued an opportunity to study abroad without succeeding. A lifetime in one place may contain serious

attempts to leave. Recovering those attempts changes our understanding of what the person wanted and tried to do, even though the eventual career or place of residence remains the same.

To follow an attempted change more closely, consider an opportunity that comes near to becoming available. A near-miss lets us examine the boundary between pursuing a path and obtaining the chance to proceed along it.

3. The Opportunities That Almost Became Real

Imagine a student who wants to become a physician and studies diligently for a standardized examination. The application route requires a qualifying score by a specified deadline. Suppose the student takes the examination but misses the required score by one point. Alternatively, an unexpected illness or disruption prevents the student from taking it before the deadline. For this illustration, no retake or exception is available within that application period.

The student chose to pursue medicine, prepared for the examination, and attempted to satisfy the requirement. Yet the opportunity to proceed in that application period did not materialize.

The student subsequently enters engineering, develops professional expertise, and enjoys a rewarding career. A later application to medicine might have remained possible, but further decisions and circumstances carry the student along the engineering path. Decades later, a career account beginning with engineering education would accurately describe the profession entered while leaving out the earlier aspiration and the event that interrupted its pursuit.

Now suppose the student exceeds the examination threshold by one point. The eligibility outcome changes: the student can proceed to the next application stage. Admission, completion of training, and a career as a physician remain subsequent possibilities, each with its own requirements.

The institutional threshold converts a small difference in examination performance into a difference in eligibility. Whether luck contributed to that difference requires further examination of preparation, capability, examination conditions, measurement variability, and other circumstances. The distinction needed here is between choosing to pursue a path and obtaining the opportunity to proceed. A narrow success and a near-miss can leave people with different options even when their aspirations and efforts are similar.

A near-miss can also make an unrealized alternative unusually easy to imagine. The student can identify the point at which the application might have continued. Research on counterfactual thinking helps explain the psychological significance of such comparisons: Kahneman and Miller's norm theory examines how people evaluate events against alternatives that readily come to mind [3], while Medvec, Madey, and Gilovich's study of Olympic medalists illustrates how proximity to a different outcome can influence emotional responses [4].

Psychological salience and historical consequence are different questions, however. An opportunity may influence a life even when the person later gives it little thought, and some opportunities disappear before the person becomes aware of them.

Someone may narrowly receive a scholarship or be selected from two finalists for employment. The favorable event changes what becomes available, just as the examination threshold does in the student's

case. Across these examples, the roads not taken include paths deliberately declined, paths pursued but never reached, and paths that never became visible.

To distinguish them in an actual life, we can seek evidence of applications, interviews, attempted transitions, institutional requirements, deadlines, and other circumstances surrounding consequential decisions. We call this historical reconstruction: establishing, as far as the evidence permits, what happened and what contributed to the realized trajectory.

Once we ask what would have happened if a narrowly missed opportunity had materialized, we face a different question.

4. Imagining Another Life

Return to the medical-school applicant.

Suppose we change one assumption: the student passes the examination rather than missing the threshold.

What follows?

The student becomes eligible for the next stage of the application process. The person might gain admission, complete medical training, and become a physician. Or subsequent experiences and constraints might lead elsewhere.

We can explore these possibilities through scenario analysis. Historical reconstruction seeks an evidence-supported account of the realized trajectory; scenario analysis investigates conditional alternatives using historical information and stated assumptions. Reconstructing the actual circumstances helps identify plausible alternatives. Considering alternative conditions can, in turn, clarify the possible significance of a historical event.

The alternative nevertheless opens further choices rather than supplying a complete second history. New experiences may influence later decisions. A near-miss can therefore identify a possible turning point while leaving the life that would have followed uncertain.

Suppose our professional had accepted the alternative job at age thirty-five.

Working elsewhere would have introduced different colleagues, responsibilities, opportunities, and risks. Those experiences might have changed the professional's knowledge, ambitions, and later decisions.

A promotion might have required relocation. An unexpected project might have encouraged a new career direction. A difficult organizational environment might have led to another job change.

The hometown resident shows how these changes can extend beyond work. Moving abroad at twenty-five might have influenced friendships, family relationships, professional interests, and personal values. Decades later, the person might have developed different expectations about what makes life satisfying.

That possibility complicates the way we judge an imagined second life. We naturally bring our present knowledge and preferences into it, although much of that knowledge and many of those preferences developed through the life actually lived. Some may remain relatively stable; others may develop differently along another path.

Consider the hometown resident who now values cultural variety and geographic exploration. The person who moved abroad at twenty-five might eventually have developed a strong desire for continuity,

belonging, and enduring local relationships. A different life could change both the experiences available and the values through which the individual later judged those experiences.

The imagined alternative is therefore more than a different route to a known destination. It is another unfolding process. To understand where such a process might diverge, we need to examine how an opportunity becomes available, what the individual attempts, and which events affect whether those attempts succeed.

5. Opportunity, Choice, and Luck

Our three examples distinguish these relationships: choosing a path does not ensure an opportunity to proceed, and obtaining the opportunity leaves further decisions and circumstances to shape what follows.

The medical-school applicant chose to pursue medicine, but proceeding depended on examination results, institutional requirements, timing, and subsequent admission decisions.

The professional's opportunity to change employers might have arisen through deliberate preparation and networking, yet its availability could also depend on an unexpected vacancy or hiring decision.

The hometown resident's ability to relocate might depend on financial resources, family obligations, educational opportunities, and circumstances outside personal control.

These influences interact. Earlier choices can help create opportunities, available opportunities affect later decisions, and unexpected events can change both. To examine the role of luck within these relationships, we need to be clear about what the term refers to.

In Luck in a Puzzling World, we distinguish several related uses: chance realization, timing, unexpected opportunity, limited control, and retrospective attribution [5]. In the present examples, a threshold determines eligibility, an opening makes a job available, and a later career gives an earlier event its apparent significance. Calling each event lucky does not establish that the same mechanism was involved.

An event can be consequential for one person without being statistically rare. Likewise, a narrow success tells us where an opportunity opened, but does not establish how much of that success reflected luck rather than capability.

Consider the professional who narrowly obtained a position and subsequently enjoyed an extraordinary career. The initial hiring decision may have created an important opportunity, but the career that followed also depended on the individual's work, subsequent decisions, relationships, and changing circumstances.

The hiring decision opened a path whose development then depended on further work and decisions. The medical-school applicant presents the same relationship. Passing the examination would have opened a further stage, while experiences and decisions along that path would still have shaped the eventual career.

Changing one event therefore gives us a starting condition for an alternative scenario, rather than a complete alternative life. Historical evidence can establish what was attempted, what circumstances permitted, and what followed. Scenario analysis explores the further possibilities under changed assumptions. Together, these activities clarify both the actual history and the points at which other paths might have opened.

6. Regret, Curiosity, and Satisfaction

Recognizing those points of divergence may leave us wondering about them long after the opportunities have passed. Curiosity is one response. Our professional may value a career while wondering about working elsewhere. The hometown resident may cherish a familiar community while wanting to know what living abroad might have offered. The engineer may enjoy the profession entered while remaining interested in medicine.

In each case, an experience of genuine interest never became part of the person's life. Wondering about it can express that interest without amounting to a judgment that the realized life was inferior.

Regret adds a different response: the unrealized possibility becomes something the person wishes had occurred. Gilovich and Medvec's review identifies a temporal pattern in which regretted actions are often more prominent in the short term, while regretted inactions become particularly salient over longer periods [6].

This finding helps us interpret the professional who declined an offer and later wonders about the career change never undertaken. The professional who applied elsewhere but received no offer has a different history: the unrealized opportunity was not simply an inaction. Elapsed time may change which alternatives attract attention without establishing the consequences those alternatives would have produced.

The content of the unrealized possibility also matters. Davidai and Gilovich report that people's most enduring regrets frequently concern unrealized aspirations associated with their ideal selves [7]. For our examples, this suggests why a path may remain meaningful when it represents someone the person hoped to become, even alongside satisfaction with the career actually pursued.

Understanding those aspirations requires returning to another feature of the second-life exercise: the person judging an earlier choice may have changed since making it.

At thirty-five, the professional may have placed particular value on financial security and family responsibilities. At sixty-five, exploration and variety may seem more attractive. Indeed, the desire for unfamiliar experiences may have developed partly because the actual life provided stability, knowledge, and opportunities for reflection. Present priorities help explain the retrospective response; the earlier priorities help explain the original decision.

A person may therefore appreciate the life that unfolded, regret some missed opportunities, and remain curious about others. These reactions answer different questions and can coexist. Satisfaction concerns what the realized life contained; regret concerns a possibility the person wishes had occurred; curiosity may concern experiences whose value remains unknown. Together, they can reveal aspirations that mattered at different points in a changing life.

7. What a Second Life Can Teach Us

Let us return to the professional who spent forty years with one company.

Suppose we discover that the individual had repeatedly applied for jobs elsewhere but never received a sufficiently attractive offer.

That discovery would not alter the observed career. But it would change our understanding of the person who lived it.

We would no longer interpret the career solely as evidence of a preference to remain. We would recognize attempts to explore other opportunities and circumstances that influenced what became possible.

Now consider two engineers with similarly successful careers.

One entered engineering through a long-standing preference. The other had initially pursued medicine but narrowly missed a qualification requirement.

Their eventual occupations may look similar, but their aspirations and decision histories differ.

Unwinding these lives reveals something that the final outcomes alone cannot show.

We might seek evidence of applications, attempted transitions, rejected offers, missed deadlines, family commitments, and changing opportunities. We might ask what the individuals knew at important decision points and what alternatives were genuinely available.

Such reconstruction could replace an incomplete interpretation of their lives with a more accurate one.

Imagining alternative scenarios offers something different. It allows us to examine how a changed circumstance might have opened other possibilities and how subsequent experiences and decisions might have developed.

The two exercises therefore have complementary value.

Historical reconstruction can deepen our understanding of the life that occurred. Scenario analysis can help us appreciate the significance of possibilities that did not become real.

Together, they can enrich how we understand personal accomplishment, disappointment, and regret.

A successful career may have emerged from an unexpected opportunity rather than a long-standing plan. A lifetime in one town may reflect valuable commitments, binding constraints, or both. A career in engineering may contain an earlier attempt to pursue medicine that remains meaningful to the person who made it.

These histories remind us that the life a person lived includes more than the choices that succeeded and the opportunities that materialized.

It also includes aspirations pursued, attempts made, constraints encountered, disappointments experienced, and adjustments undertaken when other possibilities disappeared.

Perhaps the value of imagining a second life lies less in identifying the life we should have lived than in understanding more fully how the life we actually lived came to be.

Some roads were deliberately declined. Others were pursued until circumstances made them inaccessible. Still others were never known to us. Their unrealized consequences remain uncertain, but the aspirations, attempts, and decisions associated with them belong to our actual history.

Recovering those experiences may give us a fuller understanding of our choices, the opportunities we encountered, and the circumstances through which one possible life became the life we lived.

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